

The Listening Playbook

**The Exact Words to Get Kids to Listen Without
Yelling, Nagging or Bribes**

Toddler and Child Discipline Scripts for Ages 2 to 7

A Calm Words Parenting Guide · Book 2

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Important note. This book offers general educational information about parenting and everyday behavior in young children. It is not medical, psychological or professional advice, and it does not replace care from your child's pediatrician or a licensed professional. If your child often seems not to hear you, if listening is hard for them everywhere (at home, at daycare and at school), if anyone is getting hurt, or if your child's behavior worries you, please talk to your pediatrician.

The families and children described in this book are illustrative composites, not real people. Any resemblance to a specific family is coincidental.

Find Your Moment

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Start Here: You're Not Being Ignored. Your Words Are Getting Lost.

"Shoes on, please."

Nothing.

"Shoes on. We're leaving."

Nothing. Your five-year-old is lying on the rug, making two plastic dinosaurs fight.

"Did you hear me? SHOES."

By the fifth time, you're standing over him and your voice has turned into the voice you promised yourself you'd stop using. And *now* he moves. He looks a little scared, he puts his shoes on, and you walk to the car feeling like the worst version of yourself.

If that sounds like your house, here's the first thing I want you to know: **you're not a bad parent.** You're stuck in a loop that almost every family falls into. In one national survey, 42% of parents of young children said they wish they didn't yell or raise their voice as quickly as they do.¹ You are in very large company.

And the loop can be broken. Not with more patience, more charts or a stricter voice. With a different way of asking, and a calm plan for what happens next.

1. ZERO TO THREE, "Parent Survey Reveals Expectation Gap for Parents of Young Children," *Tuning In* national parent survey (2016).

Why your words get lost

Most of the time, children don't tune us out to be rude. Our words get lost on the way.

We ask from across the room while they're deep in play. We ask a question ("Can you put your shoes on?") when we mean an instruction. We say five things at once. And then, after the first ask, nothing happens. No one walks over. No one helps. So the first ask starts to mean "not yet," and the fifth one, the loud one, starts to mean "now."

Chapter 2 explains this in more detail, and it's one of the most freeing ideas in the book: **yelling isn't what makes children listen**. It just happens to arrive at the same moment you finally get up and follow through. Keep the follow-through, drop the yell, and you get the listening without the guilt.

What this book is

This is a playbook, not a textbook. It's built to be used, not just read.

- **Part 1 (Chapters 1 to 3)** gives you the method. You'll learn the **One Clear Ask**, five small steps that make your first ask the one that counts, and the **Follow-Through Ladder**, your calm plan for when your child still doesn't do it. Read this part first. It takes about 20 minutes, and you can use it at the next "shoes on."
- **Part 2 (Chapters 4 to 10)** is the playbook itself: 30 everyday moments, from "In a minute!" to "You can't make me!", each with the exact words to say. Don't read it cover to cover. Find your moment and use it.
- **Part 3 (Chapters 11 and 12)** helps you need fewer reminders in the first place, with family rules, routines and a 14-day challenge that puts it all together.

Every moment in Part 2 follows the same layout. The words to say are always in **bold**, and every moment ends with what to do **if they still don't**, so you're never left standing there wondering what comes next.

Which book do you need?

This is Book 2 in the Calm Words Parenting series. Book 1, *The Meltdown Playbook*, is for the moments when your child is upset: screaming, crying, kicking, overwhelmed. This book is for the moments when your child is fine, but won't do what you asked.

Upset child? Feelings first. That's *The Meltdown Playbook*. **Calm child who won't do it? Ask once, follow through.** That's this book.

You don't need Book 1 to use this one. Where the two meet, I'll point you to the right page.

What this book is not

This book is for everyday listening and cooperation in children aged about 2 to 7. It is not therapy, and it can't diagnose anything. Some children find listening hard for reasons no script can fix, and that is nobody's fault. Chapter 10 explains the signs that it's time to talk to your pediatrician.

It also isn't a promise that your child will listen the first time, every time. No child does, and no adult does either. The goal is **fewer repeats**, a calmer voice, and a child who learns that when you ask, you mean it.

A few notes before you start

The scripts are starting points. Change the words so they sound like you. A script you actually say beats a perfect one you forget.

Expect some testing. When you change how you ask, many children check whether the new way is real. Use the same words and

the same follow-through for a week before you judge whether it's working.

The families in this book are illustrative. Theo, Isla, Eli and the other children you'll meet are composites, built from moments almost every family knows. They are not real people.

You don't have to be perfect. You'll still raise your voice sometimes. Every parent does. The method works even if you start it on your third ask instead of your first.

Your first step

Think about the last few days at home. Which request did you have to repeat the most? Shoes? Cleanup? Coming to the table? Stopping something?

Find it in the **Find Your Moment** list at the front of this book and mark it. That's the moment we'll work on first.

Then read Chapter 1. It's short, and you can try it before the day is over.

PART 1

Ask Once, Follow Through

Read this part tonight. It takes about 20 minutes, and you can use it tomorrow.

CHAPTER 1

One Clear Ask: Five Steps That End the Repeat Loop

Theo is four. He's on the living room floor, driving a toy truck through a city made of couch cushions. His mom is in the kitchen, draining pasta.

"Theo, can you wash your hands for dinner?"

Nothing.

"Theo. Hands. Dinner's ready."

The truck keeps driving.

"Theo, I'm not going to keep asking you!"

She does keep asking. By the fourth time she's shouting from the kitchen doorway, the pasta is going cold, and Theo finally drags himself to the sink, looking hurt.

Rewind the scene. This time, Theo's mom puts the pot down and walks over to the cushion city. She crouches beside him. "Theo." He looks up. She smiles at the truck. "Big delivery today. Hands in the sink, please. Dinner's ready." Then she waits, quietly, looking at him.

Theo parks the truck. He goes to the sink.

Same boy. Same truck. Same dinner. The difference was in *how* she asked, and it took her about ten seconds.

The One Clear Ask

The **One Clear Ask** is five small steps that turn your first ask into the one that counts. Each step fixes one of the reasons our words get lost. Child-development guides from the CDC and the Child Mind Institute give the same core advice: get close, make it clear and specific, give one direction at a time, and follow through.^{2 3} This method puts that advice in an order you can remember while the pasta is boiling over.

Here are the five steps.

1. **Get close.**
2. **Get their eyes.**
3. **Say it short.**
4. **Wait.**
5. **Follow through.**

Let's take them one at a time.

Step 1: Get Close

Walk over. Get within arm's reach if you can.

This is the step parents most want to skip, because it's easier to call from the kitchen. But a request shouted from another room is easy to miss for a busy young child. Being close tells your child, without a word, *this one matters*.

If you're worried this will take too long, compare it with the alternative. Walking over takes about ten seconds. The loop of four or five shouted asks can take five minutes, and it usually ends with both of you upset.

2. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, "Steps for Giving Good Directions" and "Tips for Giving Directions."

3. Child Mind Institute, "How to Give Kids Effective Instructions."

Tip: crouch down or sit next to them when you can. Being at their level is calmer than standing over them, and it's easier to do step 2 from there.

Step 2: Get Their Eyes

Before you ask, make sure your child is with you. Say their name and wait for them to look up. If they don't, a light touch on the shoulder or a hand near what they're playing with usually helps.

“Theo.” *[Wait for the look.]*

You can join their world for a moment first. One sentence about what they're doing shows that you noticed it, and it makes the switch to your request a little gentler:

“Big delivery today.”

“Wow, that tower is tall.”

“You're really drawing a lot of dogs.”

Keep it to one sentence. You're not starting a long chat. You're just opening the door.

Step 3: Say It Short

Now make the ask. Keep it short, clear and specific. Three rules help.

Tell, don't ask. “Can you put your shoes on?” sounds polite, but it's a question, and “no” is a perfectly good answer to a question. Make it a kind statement instead:⁴

“Shoes on, please.”

Say what to do, not what to stop. “Stop jumping!” tells your child what *not* to do, but not what to do instead.⁵ Name the behavior you want:

4. Child Mind Institute, “How to Give Kids Effective Instructions.”

5. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Steps for Giving Good Directions” and “Tips for Giving Directions.”

“Feet on the floor, please.”

One thing at a time. “Go upstairs, brush your teeth, put your pajamas on and pick a book” is four instructions. Young children have short attention spans, and one direction at a time is much easier to follow.⁶

“Teeth first, please.”

A good test: if your ask is more than ten words long, cut it. “Please” is welcome. So is a warm voice. A lecture is not.

Step 4: Wait

After you ask, stop talking and wait. Count to five slowly in your head.

This is harder than it sounds. Most of us start repeating ourselves after a second or two. But a young brain needs a few seconds to stop one thing and start another, and repeating the ask in that gap just adds more words to sort through.⁷

Stay close. Keep looking at them in a calm, friendly way. Silence plus your presence says *I’m waiting, and I’m not going anywhere*.

Very often, somewhere around four or five, your child starts to move.

Step 5: Follow Through

This is the step that makes all the others work.

If they do it, notice it. Say exactly what they did, right away.

“You put your truck down and came to wash. Thank you.”

“Shoes on, all by yourself.”

6. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Steps for Giving Good Directions” and “Tips for Giving Directions.”

7. Child Mind Institute, “How to Give Kids Effective Instructions.”

Specific words like these tell your child exactly what earned your attention, which makes it more likely to happen again.⁸

If they don't do it, don't start the loop again. Instead of asking a second, third and fourth time from further and further away, you take the next calm step yourself. In short:

- **Give one reminder, with a choice.** “Hands in the sink. Do you want to walk or hop?”
- **If they still don't, help them do it.** “I'll help you. Let's go together.” Then gently take their hand and walk with them.

That's it. No threats, no countdowns, no “How many times do I have to tell you?” You asked once, you reminded once, and then you made it happen, kindly.

Chapter 3 turns this into a full plan called the **Follow-Through Ladder**, including what to do when helping doesn't work. For today, one reminder and a helping hand are enough.

The One Clear Ask in action

Coming in from the yard:

[Walk over. Crouch.] **“Ruby.”** *[Wait for the look.]* **“Great digging. Time to come inside, please.”** *[Count to five.]* **“You came right away. Thank you.”**

Turning off the bath tap:

[Stand next to the tub.] **“Milo, look at me.”** *[Wait.]* **“Bubbles are done. Arms up for the towel, please.”** *[Count to five.]* **“Arms up. Great.”**

Stopping the couch-jumping:

[Walk over.] **“Kai.”** *[Wait.]* **“Feet on the floor, please.”** *[Count to five. No movement.]* **“Feet on the floor. You can climb down, or I can help you.”** *[Still jumping.]*

“I'll help you.” *[Lift him down calmly.]*

8. Kazdin, A. E., *The Kazdin Method for Parenting the Defiant Child* (Houghton Mifflin, 2008).

Five swaps to try this week

Small changes in wording make a big difference. Try these.

Instead of: “Can you put your shoes on?”

Try: **“Shoes on, please.”**

Instead of: “Stop running!”

Try: **“Walk next to me, please.”**

Instead of: “Clean up your room.”

Try: **“Blocks in the bin, please.”**

Instead of: “Bath time, okay?”

Try: **“Bath time.”** (Drop the “okay?” It turns the ask back into a question.)

Instead of: “How many times do I have to tell you?”

Try: [Walk over.] **“Coat on, please. I’ll wait.”**

Why your child might push back at first

The first few times you use the One Clear Ask, your child may seem surprised. Some children test it: they ignore the first ask to see whether you’ll really follow through. That’s normal. They’re checking whether the new rule is real.

Stay calm and keep going. Every time you follow through, the first ask gets a little more believable. That’s how the loop breaks: not in one day, but one kept promise at a time.

Your 5-Minute Action

1. **Pick one request you repeat every day.** Shoes, hands, coming to the table. Just one.
2. **Use all five steps for that one request, every time, for three days.** Get close, get their eyes, say it short, wait, follow through.

3. **Notice how many times you had to ask.** Don't judge it. Just notice. You'll compare it later.

That's all. You now have a better first ask.

POCKET CARD: THE ONE CLEAR ASK

1. **Get close.** Walk over. Crouch down.
2. **Get their eyes.** Say their name. Wait for the look.
3. **Say it short.** Tell, don't ask. What to do. One thing.
4. **Wait.** Count to five in your head. Don't repeat.
5. **Follow through.** Notice it, or remind once with a choice, then help.

CHAPTER 2

Why Kids Tune Out (and Why Yelling Seems to Work)

Isla is three. She's building a train track across the hallway, piece by careful piece. From the bathroom, her dad calls, "Isla, bath time!"

Isla keeps building.

"Isla! Bath!"

She clicks another piece into place.

Her dad sighs. *She heard me. She's just ignoring me.* He calls again, louder, and feels the familiar mix of tired and annoyed creeping in.

But here's the thing. Isla may have heard the sound of his voice. That doesn't mean the words made it all the way in, or that she could switch off the train in the time he gave her. To a grown-up, "bath time" is a simple request. To a three-year-old in the middle of building something, it's a much bigger ask than it sounds.

This chapter explains what's going on, so that the next time your child seems to ignore you, you know what to fix. It also explains something that confuses almost every parent: why yelling seems to be the only thing that works.

Stopping is hard work for a young brain

Think about what you're really asking when you say "bath time" to a child who's playing. You're asking them to:

- notice your voice over the game in their head,
- stop doing something they love,
- remember what "bath time" means right now,
- and start doing something else.

Each of those steps uses brain skills that grown-ups take for granted: shifting attention, holding a plan in mind, and stopping an action you want to keep doing. Researchers group these skills under the name **executive function**. Children aren't born with them. They are born with the ability to build them, and these skills keep developing through the whole of childhood and into early adulthood.⁹

So when a three-year-old doesn't stop playing the moment you ask, it's not a sign of disrespect. It's a sign of being three.

Most of us expect too much, too early

You're not alone if this surprises you. In a national survey by ZERO TO THREE, 56% of parents said children can resist doing something forbidden before age 3, and more than a third said children under 2 can do it. The same report notes that brain research shows this kind of self-control only *starts* to develop between about three and a half and four years.¹⁰

That gap between what we expect and what our children can do is behind a lot of daily frustration. When we expect instant listening from a three-year-old, every slow response feels personal. When we know that stopping is hard for them, we can make it easier, and we stay calmer while we do.

9. Center on the Developing Child at Harvard University, *InBrief: Executive Function*.

10. ZERO TO THREE, "Parent Survey Reveals Expectation Gap for Parents of Young Children," *Tuning In* national parent survey (2016).

This doesn't mean young children can't learn to listen. They can, and they do. It just means they need help to do it: a clear ask, a little time, and a grown-up who follows through.

Five ways our words get lost

Even when a child *can* listen, the way we ask can make it much harder. Here are the five most common ways a request gets lost on the way, and the step of the One Clear Ask that fixes each one.

- 1. We ask from far away.** A voice from another room is easy to tune out, especially during play. *Fix: get close.*¹¹
- 2. We ask while they're focused on something else.** Their eyes are on the train, so their attention is too. *Fix: get their eyes first.*¹²
- 3. We ask a question when we mean an instruction.** "Do you want to have your bath now?" invites "no." *Fix: tell, don't ask.*¹³
- 4. We use too many words.** A request buried in a speech, or four instructions in a row, is hard for a young child to sort out. *Fix: say it short, one thing at a time.*¹⁴
- 5. Nothing happens after the first ask.** This is the big one, and it deserves its own section.

The real reason yelling seems to work

Let's go back to Isla.

Her dad asks once from the bathroom. Nothing happens. He asks again. Nothing happens. He asks a third time, louder. Still nothing. Finally, on the fourth ask, he marches into the hallway, raises his voice, and stands over the train track. *Now* Isla gets up.

11. Child Mind Institute, "How to Give Kids Effective Instructions."

12. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, "Steps for Giving Good Directions."

13. Child Mind Institute, "How to Give Kids Effective Instructions."

14. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, "Steps for Giving Good Directions."

What did Isla learn from that evening? She learned that the first three asks didn't need an answer. Nothing happened after them. The ask that counted was the one where her dad's voice changed and he walked over.

And what did her dad learn? He learned that yelling works. Isla only moved when he yelled.

But look again. On that fourth ask, two things happened at the same time:

1. He raised his voice.
2. He walked over and made it clear that the bath was happening now.

It's very easy to give the credit to number 1. In fact, number 2 did the work. The yell just happened to arrive at the same moment as the follow-through.

Children don't learn to listen to yelling. They learn to listen to follow-through.

When the follow-through only comes with a yell, they learn to wait for the yell. When the follow-through comes calmly, on the first ask, they learn to listen to the first ask.

So the fix isn't to stop caring, or to never raise your voice again. It's simpler than that:

Keep the follow-through. Drop the yell.

Yelling costs more than it gives

There's another reason to move the follow-through earlier. Yelling doesn't work as well as it seems to.

The American Academy of Pediatrics reviewed the research on discipline and concluded that harsh approaches, including yelling at or shaming children, do little to change behavior in the short term and don't work in the long term.¹⁵ A yell may get your child

moving tonight, but it doesn't teach them to listen tomorrow. And once the yell is the signal that counts, your child has every reason to keep waiting for it.

If you read that and felt a pang of guilt, please hear this too: you are far from the only one. In a large national study of American parents, almost all said they had yelled, screamed or shouted at their child to correct behavior.¹⁶ Yelling isn't a sign that you're a bad parent. It's a sign that you're a parent without a better plan for the moment after "no." This book is that plan.

Connection before direction

There's one more reason children tune us out, and it's a gentle one. Often, our asks arrive out of nowhere. We've been busy, they've been busy, and then suddenly we appear with an instruction.

A few seconds of connection before the ask can make a big difference. That's why Step 2 of the One Clear Ask includes joining their world for a moment:

"That's a long track! Two more pieces, then bath."

"Your dragon looks fierce. Time to put him to sleep for dinner."

Notice the second example. It doesn't just connect. It gives the child a way to finish the game in their own head, which makes stopping easier.

If you've read *The Meltdown Playbook*, this will sound familiar. It's the same idea as the first step of the Calm Words Formula: show your child that you see what they care about before you ask for something. Children who feel seen are more willing to switch gears.

15. Sege, R. D., & Siegel, B. S., "Effective Discipline to Raise Healthy Children," *Pediatrics* 142(6), American Academy of Pediatrics (2018).

16. Straus, M. A., & Field, C. J., "Psychological Aggression by American Parents: National Data on Prevalence, Chronicity, and Severity," *Journal of Marriage and Family* 65(4), 795–808 (2003).

You don't need to do this every single time. But for the hard transitions (leaving the park, ending a game, bath time, bedtime), a moment of connection is time well spent.

What to fix first

None of this means you've been doing it wrong. It means you now know which levers to pull. The biggest one is the moment after you've asked clearly, waited, and your child still doesn't move. That's where most families slide back into the repeat loop, and it's what Chapter 3 is about.

Your 5-Minute Action

Count your asks for one hour. Pick a busy hour (the morning rush, or the hour before dinner) and keep a quick tally on your phone or a sticky note. Every instruction you give your child gets a mark. Every *repeat* of an instruction gets a circle.

No judgment, no fixing. Just count.

Most parents are surprised by both numbers. If your marks are high, Chapter 11 will help you cut the number of instructions you need to give. If your circles are high, Chapter 3 is about to help with that.

. . .

CHAPTER 3

What to Do When They Still Don't: The Follow-Through Ladder

Eli is five. There are building bricks across the whole living room floor, and dinner is ready in ten minutes.

His mom has read Chapter 1. She walks over, crouches down, and waits until Eli looks up. "That's a huge spaceship. Bricks in the bin, please. Dinner's almost ready." Then she waits and counts to five in her head.

Eli looks at her. Then he looks back at his spaceship and keeps building.

This is the moment where most parents slide back into the old loop. You asked nicely. You did everything right. And your child still didn't do it. The next thing out of your mouth is usually a repeat, then a louder repeat, then a threat.

This chapter gives you something better: a calm, step-by-step plan for the moment after "no." It's called the **Follow-Through Ladder**, and once you know it, you'll never again have to wonder what comes next.

The Follow-Through Ladder

The ladder has four rungs. You start at the bottom and climb only as far as you need to. Most of the time, you'll stop at the first or second rung.

Rung 1: One reminder, with a choice.

Rung 2: Helping hands, or “When... then...”

Rung 3: A calm consequence.

Rung 4: Move on.

The ladder works for two reasons. First, every rung is calm. Nothing on it requires a raised voice. Second, it's predictable. Your child soon learns that once you've asked, the ask will happen, one way or another. That predictability is what makes the first ask start to count.

Rung 1: One Reminder, With a Choice

If your child hasn't started after you've waited, give **one** reminder. This is the only repeat on the whole ladder.

Make the reminder a little different from the first ask by adding a choice. The choice is never about *whether* the task happens. It's about *how*.

“Bricks in the bin. Do you want to start with the red ones or the blue ones?”

“Shoes on. Do you want to sit on the step or on the floor?”

“Time for your bath. Do you want to hop there like a frog or walk like a robot?”

Choices work because they give your child a small piece of control in a moment where they feel they have none. A child choosing between red and blue bricks has stopped arguing about whether to clean up.

Two rules for good choices: keep it to two, and only offer options you're happy with either way.

If a consequence might follow, Rung 1 is where you say so. Give one calm warning, so your child knows exactly what will happen.

¹⁷ Keep it a fact, not a threat:

“Bricks in the bin, please. Any bricks still on the floor will go on the high shelf until tomorrow.”

Then wait again. Count to five.

Rung 2: Helping Hands, or “When... Then...”

If your child still hasn’t started, you don’t ask a third time. You help it happen.

Helping hands works for anything you can physically help with, and it’s especially good for toddlers and preschoolers.

“I’ll help you get started. You put one in, I’ll put one in.”

“Your hands or my hands?” [*Then gently guide their hands, or do it together.*]

“Let’s go together.” [*Take their hand and walk to the bathroom.*]

Helping isn’t giving in. You’re not doing the task *for* them. You’re doing it *with* them, so it gets done and they’re part of it. For many young children, the hard part was getting started. Once your hands are in the bin, theirs often follow.

“When... then...” works for things you can’t physically help with, or for older children who don’t want hands-on help. It links the task to what naturally comes next.

“When the bricks are in the bin, then we’ll go outside.”

“When your pajamas are on, then we’ll read the story.”

“When your coat is on, then we’ll go to the park.”

17. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Steps for Giving Good Directions.”

Notice the word *when*, not *if*. “If you put the bricks away...” makes it sound optional. “*When*” says it’s going to happen; the only question is how soon.

Also notice what comes after “then.” It’s something that was going to happen anyway: going outside, the story, the park. You’re not inventing a new prize. You’re just making the order clear.

Rung 3: A Calm Consequence

If your child still won’t, it’s time for a consequence. This is the rung parents worry about most, so here’s what a consequence is, and what it isn’t.

A good consequence is **related, small and soon**. The American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry advises that, whenever possible, consequences should come right away, relate to the rule that was broken, and be short enough that you can move on quickly.¹⁸

Related. It’s connected to what happened. Bricks left on the floor go on the high shelf. Water splashed out of the tub means bath time ends. The lesson makes sense to your child.

Small. It’s short. The rest of the afternoon, not the rest of the month. A small consequence you’ll actually do teaches far more than a huge one you won’t.

Soon. It happens now, not on Saturday. For a young child, a consequence that comes days later isn’t connected to anything.

And say it calmly, with no extra words:

“You didn’t put the bricks away, so the bricks are going on the high shelf until tomorrow.”

Then do it. Pick up the bricks, without anger, and put them on the shelf.

18. American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry, *Facts for Families* No. 43, “Discipline.”

Your child may cry or protest. That's fine. You don't need to argue, explain again or take it back. You can say, **"You're disappointed. You can try again tomorrow."** The consequence does the teaching. Your calm keeps it from turning into a fight.

What a consequence is not

Consequences are not punishments meant to make a child suffer. They're not yelling, shaming, name-calling or hitting. The American Academy of Pediatrics concluded that harsh approaches like these don't work in the long term,¹⁹ and child psychiatrists advise against yelling and name-calling too.²⁰

A good consequence also never takes away something your child *needs*: food, sleep, comfort, or their time with you.

Threats you won't keep

"If you don't clean up right now, we're never going to the park again!" "No birthday party!" "I'm throwing all your toys in the trash!"

We've all said things like this. They come out when we're out of ideas. But they're big, far away and almost impossible to carry out, and children learn that quickly. Each empty threat teaches your child that your words don't always mean what they say, which is exactly the opposite of what we want.

If you hear a threat coming, stop and swap it for a small, related consequence you know you'll follow through on.

Rung 4: Move On

This is the rung most parents forget, and it matters more than it seems.

19. Sege, R. D., & Siegel, B. S., "Effective Discipline to Raise Healthy Children," *Pediatrics* 142(6), American Academy of Pediatrics (2018).

20. American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry, *Facts for Families* No. 43, "Discipline."

Once the task is done (or the consequence has happened), **it's over**. No lecture. No "I told you so." No bringing it up again at dinner. No cold shoulder for the rest of the evening.

"Okay. Dinner time. Come sit with me."

Moving on shows your child that the ask was about the bricks, not about whether you love them. It also gives the next ask a fresh start. A child who's still in trouble from the last ask has very little reason to cooperate with the next one.

Later, when things are calm, you can catch the good moments. That's next.

Catch Them Listening

The ladder handles the moments when your child doesn't listen. But the fastest way to get more listening is to notice the times they *do*.

Psychologist Alan Kazdin calls this looking for the **positive opposite**: decide what you want your child to do, then notice and praise it when it happens.²¹ The praise works best when it's specific and comes right away. "I saw that you put your toys away!" tells your child exactly what to do again. "Good job!" doesn't.²²

"You came the first time I asked. Thank you."

"You turned off the tablet when the timer rang. That was hard, and you did it."

"You put your shoes on while I got your coat. That helped us get out the door."

Aim to notice more listening than you correct. It feels strange at first, especially on a hard day. But children work hard for attention, and this is the kind of attention you want them working for.

21. Kazdin, A. E., *The Kazdin Method for Parenting the Defiant Child* (Houghton Mifflin, 2008).

22. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, "Using Rewards."

Rewards and Bribes: What's the Difference?

Parents often ask whether rewards are just bribes with a nicer name. Here's how this book draws the line.

A reward is agreed before, when everyone is calm.

“When you're dressed before the timer rings, you get to pick the song in the car.”

A bribe is offered in the middle of a standoff, to make it stop.

“Okay, okay, if you put your shoes on *right now*, you can have a cookie.”

The reward teaches: *doing the task gets something good*. The bribe teaches: *refusing long enough makes the offers get better*. Same cookie, very different lesson.

Rewards work best when they come right after the behavior,²³ and the best ones are often small: picking the song, an extra story, five minutes of your full attention. Keep the rewards for the hardest tasks, and let your specific praise do the rest of the work.

Two Times to Skip the Ladder

When safety is at stake, skip straight to action. If your child is running toward the street, reaching for the stove, or about to hurt someone, don't count to five. Move, block, pick them up, hold their hand. Talk about it afterward, once everyone is safe.

When “won't” turns into a meltdown, switch to feelings first. Sometimes a child on the ladder stops refusing and starts falling apart: crying, screaming, kicking, overwhelmed. A child in a meltdown can't follow instructions. Pause the ladder, help them calm down, and come back to the task once they're calm. The task still happens; it just happens later.

If you have *The Meltdown Playbook*, this is where its 3-Line Meltdown Script comes in: “I see you're _____. I'm right here. I won't let

you ___.” If you don’t, a calm voice, few words and staying close will carry you through.

The Ladder in Action

Let’s go back to Eli and his spaceship.

His mom has asked once and waited. Eli kept building. So she moves to **Rung 1:**

“Bricks in the bin. Do you want to start with the wings or the engine?”

Eli says, “No! I’m not done!”

She stays calm and adds the warning: **“Bricks on the floor will go on the high shelf until tomorrow.”** Then she waits.

Eli doesn’t move. So she climbs to **Rung 2**, helping hands:

“I’ll help you start. I’ll take off one wing, you take off the other.”

She takes a wing apart and drops the pieces in the bin. Eli watches. Then, grumbling, he pulls off the other wing. They finish together in two minutes.

Rung 4: “Done. Thanks for finishing. Let’s go eat.” No lecture about how it should have happened the first time.

Eli’s mom never needed Rung 3 that night. That’s how it goes most of the time. The ladder isn’t about consequences. It’s about always knowing your next calm step, so you never need the yell.

23. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Using Rewards.”

Your 5-Minute Action

Fill in your Consequence Picker. Choose the three moments at home where you most often end up repeating yourself or yelling. For each one, write down:

1. **A related, small, soon consequence** you'd be willing to carry out every time.
2. **The exact words** you'll use to give the warning at Rung 1.

Do this now, while you're calm. In the moment, you won't have to think. You'll just read the words you already chose.

PRINTABLE: MY CONSEQUENCE PICKER*Related · Small · Soon · Said calmly***Hard moment A:** _____

Consequence: _____

How long: _____

My warning words: “ _____ ”

Hard moment B: _____

Consequence: _____

How long: _____

My warning words: “ _____ ”

Hard moment C: _____

Consequence: _____

How long: _____

My warning words: “ _____ ”

Some ideas to get you started:

- **Toys not put away:** they go on a high shelf until tomorrow.
- **Tablet not turned off when the timer rings:** no more tablet today.
- **Crayons on the wall or table:** crayons are put away for the afternoon, and we wipe it together.
- **Water splashed out of the bath:** bath time ends now.
- **Riding the bike past the corner:** the bike goes in the garage for the rest of the day.
- **Throwing sand at the playground:** we leave the sandbox and play somewhere else.

POCKET CARD: THE FOLLOW-THROUGH LADDER

1. **One reminder, with a choice.** Add the warning if a consequence is coming.
2. **Helping hands, or “When... then...”** Do it with them, or link it to what’s next.
3. **A calm consequence.** Related. Small. Soon. Said once.
4. **Move on.** No lecture. No grudge. Fresh start.

Safety first: skip the ladder and act. Meltdown: feelings first, task later.

PART 2

The Playbook: 30 Moments, 30 Scripts

Don't read this part cover to cover. Find your moment, read the bold line, and go.

How to use a script card

Every moment in Part 2 has the same six parts, so you always know where to look.

- **What's going on:** one or two lines on why this moment is hard for your child.
- **Say this:** the ask. Use the One Clear Ask: get close, get their eyes, then say it.
- **If they still don't:** your next steps on the Follow-Through Ladder (Chapter 3).
- **Instead of / Try:** a common phrase that backfires, and a swap.
- **Age tweaks:** small changes for ages 2–3, 4–5 and 6–7.
- **Next time:** one idea to make the moment easier before it starts.

The ladder at a glance: Rung 1, one reminder, with a choice. Rung 2, helping hands or “When... then...” Rung 3, a calm consequence: related, small, soon. Rung 4, move on.

The bold lines are the words to say. Everything in brackets is what to *do*. And after every ask, wait. Count to five in your head before anything else.

If you only have ten seconds, read the **Say this** line and go.

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CHAPTER 4

“In a Minute!”: When They Tune You Out

Hazel is four. She’s at the kitchen table with a pile of stickers, and her mom has asked her to get her coat three times. Each time, Hazel says “Okay!” and keeps sticking.

It’s not that Hazel is being rude. She really does mean “okay.” She just means it in the way four-year-olds do: *okay, at some point, once this sticker is on.*

The moments in this chapter are the quiet ones. No screaming, no stomping. Just a child who doesn’t seem to hear you, or hears you and doesn’t move. They’re also the moments where the repeat loop starts, which makes them the best place to break it.

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Moment 1: “Did you hear me?”

Ignoring you in the middle of play

What’s going on: Your child’s whole attention is on the game. Your voice may not even register as something they need to answer, especially from across the room. Switching attention away from play is a skill they’re still building.

Say this:

[Walk over. Crouch down. Say their name and wait for the look.]

“That’s a big sticker picture. Coat on, please.”

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* “Coat on. Do you want to put it on by yourself or with my help?”
- *Rung 2:* “Let’s do it together.” [*Hold the coat open and guide one arm in.*]
- *Rung 4:* “Coat’s on. Thank you. Let’s go.”

Instead of: “Did you hear me? I said COAT!” (from the hallway)

Try: [*Walk over.*] “Hazel. Look at me. Coat on, please.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Use one or two words and a gesture. Point at the coat: “Coat on.”
- 4–5: Let them finish one small thing first: “One more sticker, then coat.”
- 6–7: Ask them to repeat it back: “What’s next?” “Coat.” “Yep.”

Next time: Give a heads-up before the ask. “Two more stickers, then it’s coat time.”

A concrete number is easier to follow than “in a few minutes.”

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Moment 2: “Come here!”

Calling them to you, or time to come inside

What’s going on: “Come here” means stopping, leaving and walking away, all at once. When it means coming in from outside, it also means the fun is over. Calling from the back door makes it easy to pretend they didn’t hear.

Say this:

[Walk out to them. Get close.]

“Time to come inside, please. Snack is ready.”

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* "Inside now. Do you want to race me to the door or walk like a dinosaur?"
- *Rung 2:* "When you're inside, then you can pick the game." Or take their hand and walk in together.
- *Rung 3:* "Coming in was hard today, so after snack we'll play inside."

Instead of: "If you don't come right now, I'm leaving without you!"

Try: "I'm coming to get you. Let's go in together."

Age tweaks:

- 2-3: Make it a game: crouch down, open your arms and say "Run to me!"
- 4-5: Give them a job for the walk in: "Can you carry the shovel?"
- 6-7: Agree on the signal ahead of time: "When I ring the bell, it's time to come in."

Next time: Practice "come here" as a game when nothing is at stake. Call, and when they come, give a high five and send them back to play. Children learn that coming to you doesn't always mean the fun ends.

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Moment 3: "In a minute!"

The stall

What's going on: Your child really does want to finish what they're doing. That's reasonable. The trouble is that "a minute" has no end, so it turns into ten.

Say this:

"You want to finish. One more page, then teeth."

[Wait while they finish the page.]

“That was the last page. Teeth now, please.”

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* **“Teeth now. Do you want to hop to the bathroom or tiptoe?”**
- *Rung 2:* **“I’ll walk with you.”** *[Take their hand.]*
- *Rung 4:* No lecture about the stalling. **“Teeth are done. Story time.”**

Instead of: “Fine, five more minutes.” (And then forgetting, and saying it again.)

Try: “Let’s set the timer together. When it beeps, it’s teeth time.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: “One more” works better than any minutes. **“One more push of the car, then teeth.”**
- 4–5: A visual timer they can watch helps them see the time running out.
- 6–7: Let them suggest the finish line: **“Do you want to finish the page or the chapter?”** Then hold them to it.

Next time: Give the warning *before* they have to ask for more time. Kids ask for “a minute” less when they already know where the finish line is.

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Moment 4: “Stop that!”

Jumping on the couch, banging, poking

What’s going on: Young children often have big energy and few ideas for where to put it. “Stop!” tells them what not to do, but not what to do instead.

Say this:

[Walk over.]

"Feet on the floor, please. Jumping is for outside."

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* **"Feet on the floor. You can jump on the cushions on the floor, or outside."**
- *Rung 2:* **"I'll help you down."** *[Lift them down calmly.]*
- *Rung 3:* **"The couch is closed for now. You can sit on it again after lunch."**

Instead of: "Stop it! Stop! I said STOP!"

Try: Say what to do. **"Gentle hands on the dog."** **"Drums are for the pots, not the window."** **"Walking feet inside."**

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Move them, then show them. **"Jump here!"** and jump on the cushion with them.
- 4–5: Offer a choice of where the energy can go: **"Jump on the cushions or dance with me?"**
- 6–7: Explain once: **"The couch springs break. The floor cushions don't."**

Next time: Plan an energy outlet for the times it usually happens, like a "jump spot" with cushions on the floor, or a dance song before dinner.

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Moment 5: "But Dad lets me!"

Listens to one parent (or the sitter) but not the other

What's going on: Children notice which adult follows through and which one repeats. They aren't choosing a favorite. They're reading the pattern. If one adult asks once and then helps, and the other asks five times, the child learns to wait for the fifth time with that adult.

Say this:

[To your child, using the One Clear Ask.]

“Shoes on, please. I’ll wait.”

[To the other adult, later, when you’re both calm.]

“Can we use the same words for shoes and bedtime this week?

Ask once, then help.”

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* **“Shoes on. Red ones or blue ones?”**
- *Rung 2:* **“I’ll help.”** If the other parent is there, they back you up without taking over: **“Mom asked. I’ll wait with you.”**

Instead of: “Wait till your father gets home!”

Try: “I asked you. I’ll help you do it.” (You don’t need anyone else to follow through.)

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Use the exact same few words as the other adult. “Shoes on” from both of you.
- **4–5:** If they say “Dad lets me!”, answer once: **“With me, the rule is...”**
- **6–7:** Agree on a family rule together and say it the same way: **“In our family, we...”**

Next time: Pick three phrases every adult in the house will use, plus one consequence you’ll all follow through on. Chapter 10 has more on getting the grown-ups on the same page.

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Moment 6: “Can I? Can I? Can I?”

The broken record

What’s going on: If asking ten times has ever worked, asking ten times is a smart plan. Your child is checking whether “no” is really no.

Say this:

[Answer once, clearly.]

"The answer is no for today. You can ask me again tomorrow."

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* **"I heard you. My answer is the same."**
- *Rung 2:* **"Asked and answered."** Then turn your attention to something else. The CDC suggests redirecting your attention for minor behaviors like whining or interrupting, and warns that the behavior may get worse when you first start.²⁴
- *Rung 4:* The moment they stop asking, give them your full attention again. **"Want to help me with the laundry?"**

Instead of: "Fine! Just stop asking!"

Try: "I said no, and I'm not going to change my mind. Do you want to help me with the dishes or play next to me?"

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Name it and move them along: **"No cookie. Here's your cup."** Then change the scene.
- **4–5:** Give a "yes" that's possible: **"No cookie now. Yes to an apple."**
- **6–7:** Teach them how to ask well: one time, in a calm voice. **"If you want me to think about it, ask me once, and I'll give you a real answer."**

Next time: If you really aren't sure yet, say so. **"Let me think. I'll tell you after lunch."** A thoughtful "maybe" beats a "no" that turns into "yes" after the tenth ask.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Pick your top two tune-out moments from this chapter. For the next five days, use the card for both of them every time they come

up. Same words, same follow-through. Keep your tally from Chapter 2 going and watch the circles.

. . .

24. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Redirecting Attention.”

CHAPTER 5

“You’re Not the Boss of Me!”: No, Defiance and Power Struggles

Jonah is five. His dad asks him to turn off the tablet and brush his teeth. Jonah crosses his arms, looks his dad right in the eye and says, “No. You can’t make me.”

His dad feels it land like a slap. *Did my five-year-old just challenge me?* The urge to win is strong. Louder voice, bigger threat, whatever it takes.

But here’s the thing about power struggles: it takes two people to have one. The moments in this chapter go best when you don’t pick up the rope. You don’t need to win the argument. You just need to follow through on the ask, calmly, while your child has their feelings about it.

Testing limits is a normal part of growing up. It isn’t a sign that your child is bad or that you’ve lost control. It’s your child checking whether the rules are real. Each calm follow-through answers the question: *yes, they are.*

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Moment 7: “No!”

The flat refusal

What’s going on: “No” is one of the first ways a young child feels powerful. Often it comes out automatically, before they’ve even thought about the ask.

Say this:

[Don't argue with the "no." Restate the ask as a calm fact, with a choice.]

"Coat on. Do you want to zip it yourself, or should I?"

If they still don't:

- *Rung 2: "I'll help you." [Hold the coat and guide their arms in. Calm hands, no fuss.]*
- *Rung 4: "Coat's on. Let's go see the ducks."*

Instead of: "Don't you say no to me!"

Try: Let the word go by. Answer the ask, not the "no." **"Coat on. I'll help."**

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Fewer words, more doing. **"Coat on,"** then gently help. Many toddlers say no and then cooperate once they're moving.
- **4–5:** Give them a bigger choice: **"Coat or sweater?"** Either one works for you.
- **6–7:** Acknowledge the no once: **"You don't want to. I get it. Coat on, please."**

Next time: Ask fewer yes-or-no questions, and give your child plenty of safe chances to say no where it doesn't matter. **"Do you want peas? No? Okay!"** A child who gets to say no sometimes has less need to say it all the time.

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Moment 8: "You can't make me!"

The power challenge

What's going on: Your child is testing who's in charge. And in a way, they're right: you can't make them *want* to brush their teeth. But you're in charge of what happens next.

Say this:

"You're right. I can't make you want to. Teeth now, please, and then we'll read."

[Then stop talking and wait.]

If they still don't:

- **Rung 2: "When your teeth are brushed, then we'll read the story."** *[Wait in the bathroom doorway.]*
- **Rung 3: "We used up story time, so tonight it's one short song instead. We'll try again tomorrow."** *[Brush teeth together, calmly, then sing the song.]* The time used up is the story, not your closeness. Your child still gets you at bedtime.
- **Rung 4: "Good night. I love you."** No cold shoulder.

Instead of: "Oh, yes I can!" (Now you're in a contest, and you both want to win.)

Try: "I can't make you. I can tell you what happens next."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Rarely said in these words. If it is, skip the talk and use helping hands.
- **4-5:** Keep it short. The fewer words you use, the less there is to argue with.
- **6-7:** Later, when calm, ask: **"What would make teeth time easier?"** They may have a good idea.

Next time: Give your child real control in other places: picking the pajamas, choosing the book, deciding which tooth to brush first. A child who feels in charge of some things fights less over the rest.

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Moment 9: Running off when you call

Including the safety version

What's going on: For many young children, running away when called is a great game. You chase, they laugh. They don't yet understand danger the way adults do.

First, the safety rule. Near streets, parking lots, water or crowds, **skip the ladder.**

Hold hands *before* the danger starts. If your child runs, catch them and carry them. Skip the warnings and the choices, and talk about it afterward.

Say this (before getting out of the car):

"Parking lot rule: hands hold my hand or the car. Which one?"

Say this (in a safe, fenced place):

[Don't chase. Stop, crouch down and call once.]

"Freeze! Come back to me, please."

If they still don't:

- *Rung 2:* Walk to them calmly and take their hand. **"We're walking together now."**
- *Rung 3:* **"You ran away from me, so you'll ride in the stroller (or hold my hand) the rest of the way."**

Instead of: Chasing them, laughing or yelling. (It makes the game more fun.)

Try: In safe places, don't play the chase. In unsafe places, don't give them the chance: hold hands first.

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Use the stroller, a cart or a carrier near danger. Toddlers can't be trusted to stop, however well they know the rule.
- **4-5:** Practice "Freeze!" at home as a game, and give big praise for freezing.

- **6–7:** Explain the danger once, simply: **"Drivers can't see small people between cars."**

Next time: Play the Freeze game often when nothing is at stake. Call "Freeze!", they stop, you cheer. Practice now makes the real thing more likely to work.

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Moment 10: Doing it while looking right at you

Testing the rule

What's going on: Your child is running an experiment: *What happens if I do it again?* If the answer is a big reaction, that's interesting and worth repeating. Psychologist Alan Kazdin points out that attention to unwanted behavior tends to increase it, while attention to the behavior you want increases that instead.²⁵

Say this:

[Calm, boring voice. Same words every time.]

"Cup stays on the table. If it drops again, the cup goes away."

If they still don't:

- *Rung 3:* *[Quietly take the cup away.]* **"The cup dropped, so it's going away for now."**
- *Rung 4:* Move on. A few minutes later, offer it back: **"Want to try again? Cup stays on the table."**

Instead of: A big reaction: gasping, raised voice, a long speech.

Try: The most boring follow-through you can manage. Save your excitement for the good moments: **"You kept your cup on the table the whole meal!"**

25. Kazdin, A. E., *The Kazdin Method for Parenting the Defiant Child* (Houghton Mifflin, 2008).

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Toddlers drop things to learn how the world works, too. Remove the item without any fuss, and give them something they *can* drop, like a ball.
- **4–5:** Say the rule and the consequence once, then act.
- **6–7:** If it's a pattern, talk later: **"I noticed you kept doing it while you looked at me. What was going on?"**

Next time: Catch them doing the right thing, a lot. Children who get plenty of attention for good behavior have less reason to test for the other kind.

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Moment 11: "But why?"

The little lawyer

What's going on: Some whys are real curiosity. But a "why" right after an ask is often a way to delay it or start a debate.

Say this:

[Give one short reason, once.]

"Teeth now, because the sugar bugs come out at night."

If they still don't:

- **Rung 1:** **"I told you why. Teeth now, please. Big brush or little brush?"**
- **Rung 2:** **"Great question. Ask me again after your teeth are brushed, and I'll tell you more."** *[Walk with them to the bathroom.]*

Instead of: A long explanation, then a debate about the explanation.

Try: One reason, then the ask again. Save the long talks for calm times.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Skip the reason. **"Teeth time,"** and help.
- **4–5:** A short, concrete reason helps: **"so your teeth stay strong."**
- **6–7:** They may want to argue the reason. Don't. **"That's a good thing to talk about after."**

Next time: Explain your family's rules when everyone is calm. Child psychiatrists recommend setting clear rules and explaining why they matter.²⁶ A child who already knows the why has less need to ask it in the moment.

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Moment 12: Breaking a rule you just set

"I said no ball in the house."

What's going on: Young children's memory for rules is short, especially when the ball is right there. Sometimes it's forgetting. Sometimes it's testing. You don't need to work out which. The response is the same.

Say this:

"Rule check: balls are for outside. Do you want to take it outside or put it in the basket?"

If they still don't:

- *Rung 3:* **"The ball is going on the shelf until after lunch."** [*Put it away calmly.*]
- *Rung 4:* After lunch, give it back, and go outside together if you can.

Instead of: "What did I JUST say?"

Try: **"Rule check."** Two words that remind without blaming.

26. American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry, *Facts for Families* No. 43, "Discipline."

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Move the temptation. Toddlers can't resist a ball in the living room. Put it where they can't reach it.
- **4–5:** Let them remind you of the rule: **"What's the ball rule?"**
- **6–7:** Make the rule together: **"Where should balls go so nothing breaks?"**

Next time: Fewer rules, said the same way every time. Three to five clear family rules work better than twenty. Chapter 11 shows you how to write yours.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Choose one battle to drop and one to hold. Look at the struggles you have most often. Pick one that doesn't really matter (mismatched socks, the blue cup) and let it go this week. Then pick one that does matter, and hold it every time with the same calm words. You can't win every battle, and you don't need to. Pick the ones worth following through on.

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CHAPTER 6

Toys Away, Hands Helping: Cleanup and Chores

Clara is six. Getting dressed for school should take five minutes. This morning, it has taken twenty. One sock is on. The other is somewhere under the bed. Clara is lying on the floor, telling a long story to her stuffed rabbit.

Her mom has said “Get dressed!” more times than she can count. Every time, Clara says “I am!” and keeps not getting dressed.

Cleanup, chores and getting ready all have the same problem: to a young child, they’re boring, they’re slow, and they feel enormous. “Clean your room” sounds like one task to us. To a four-year-old, it’s a mountain with no path up it. The moments in this chapter work by making the mountain smaller: one step at a time, often side by side with you.

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Moment 13: Toy cleanup

“Clean up this mess!”

What’s going on: “Clean up” is too big and too vague for a young child. They don’t know where to start, so they don’t.

Say this:

[Get close. Give one specific step.]

“Cars in the red bin, please.”

[When the cars are in:] **“Cars done! Now books on the shelf.”**

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* “Cars in the bin. Do you want to beat the timer or beat the song?”
- *Rung 2:* “You do the cars, I’ll do the blocks.” [*Start cleaning beside them.*]
- *Rung 3:* “The toys still on the floor are going in the put-away box until tomorrow.”

Instead of: “Clean up your room!” (from the doorway)

Try: “Blocks in the bin. Then books on the shelf. Then we’re done.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: One kind of toy at a time, with you. Sing a cleanup song while you do it.
- 4–5: Make it a race against a song or a timer. Lots of four-year-olds love beating a song.
- 6–7: A picture checklist on the door: bed, floor, books. They tick it off themselves.

Next time: Fewer toys out at once, and clean up before the next activity starts. “When the trains are away, then we’ll get the paints out.”

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Moment 14: “I can’t do it!”

When they can

What’s going on: Your child may be tired, the task may feel too big, or they may just want some of your help and closeness. It isn’t a trick. It’s usually a request for connection dressed up as helplessness.

Say this:

“You can do the first part. You put your foot in, and I’ll help with the strap.”

If they still don't:

- *Rung 2: "Let's do it together this time." [Do it side by side, calmly.]*
- *Rung 4: "All done. Tomorrow you can show me how you do it by yourself."*

Instead of: "You're a big kid, you can do it yourself!"

Try: "I'll start it, you finish it."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** They often really can't yet. Do it together and name each step as you go.
- **4-5:** Break it down: **"First the arm. Now the other arm. Now the zip."**
- **6-7:** Offer help with one part only: **"Which part do you want help with?"**

Next time: Practice new skills when nobody is in a hurry, like doing up a coat on a Saturday, not at 7:50 on a school morning. A skill practiced when everyone is calm is easier to use under pressure.

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Moment 15: The 20-minute dawdle

Getting dressed, putting shoes on, finishing anything

What's going on: Getting dressed is several tasks pretending to be one. Every pause between steps is a chance to wander off into a game. Your child isn't slow on purpose. The steps just aren't holding their attention.

Say this:

[Stay close. One step at a time.]

"Socks." *[Wait.]* **"Now shirt."** *[Wait.]* **"Now pants."**

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1: "Shirt next. Do you want to race me or race the timer?"*

- **Rung 2:** “When you’re dressed, then you can play until we leave.” Whatever time is left after getting dressed is playtime, so dawdling uses up their own play.
- **Rung 4:** No complaining in the car about how long it took. “You got dressed. Let’s go.”

Instead of: “Hurry up! Hurry up! We’re going to be late!”

Try: “Shirt next. I’ll watch.” Your calm presence keeps them on track better than “hurry.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Dress them, and let them do one part: “You pull the sock up.”
- **4–5:** A picture chart of the steps, so they can see what’s next without you saying it.
- **6–7:** Lay clothes out the night before and let them dress themselves while you’re nearby.

Next time: Get clothes ready the night before, and get dressed before anything fun, like a show or playtime. *First* dressed, *then* fun.

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Moment 16: Bath time

Getting in, and getting out

What’s going on: Getting into the bath means stopping play. Getting out means stopping a different kind of play. Both are transitions, and transitions are hard.

Safety first: stay with your child the whole time they’re in the bath.

Say this (getting in):

“Bath time. Do you want to bring the ducks or the boat?”

Say this (getting out):

“Two more splashes, then the plug comes out.”

[After two splashes:] **“Plug out. Arms up for the towel.”**

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 2: “Your hands or my hands?” [Lift them out calmly and wrap them in the towel.]*
- *Rung 3 (for splashing water out of the tub): “Water stays in the tub. If it splashes out again, bath time is over.”* If it does, calmly pull the plug and lift them out.

Instead of: “Get in the bath NOW!” or “Get out, the water’s freezing, I’m not telling you again!”

Try: “Plug out in two splashes.” Let the plug do the talking.

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Let them pull the plug and wave bye-bye to the water.
- 4–5: Make getting out a game: “Can you get out like a penguin?”
- 6–7: Let them set the timer: “Ten minutes or fifteen?” Then the timer is the boss.

Next time: Keep the same order every night: bath, pajamas, teeth, story. When the next step is always the same, it’s easier to move toward it.

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Moment 17: Helping around the house

Setting the table, laundry, feeding the pet

What’s going on: Many young children love to help, just not at the moment you ask, and not with the job you picked. Real jobs can help children feel that they belong and that they matter in the family.

Say this:

“Table captain! Can you put a spoon by every plate, please?”

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* “Spoons or napkins? You pick.”
- *Rung 2:* “Let’s do it together. You carry, I’ll set.”
- *Rung 4:* “You set the spoons. Dinner looks great because of you.”

Instead of: “You never help around here!”

Try: Give the job a name and a title. “Table captain,” “sock matcher,” “fish feeder.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Tiny jobs with you: carry the napkins, put socks in the basket.
- **4–5:** One job of their own, the same one every day.
- **6–7:** Two or three jobs on a chart they can check off themselves.

Next time: Make the job part of a routine, not a request. When “table captain” happens every dinner, you’ll find yourself asking less and less.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Give your child one real job and a name for it. Pick something small they can do every day. Tell them their title, show them how to do it once, and thank them specifically each time they do it.

PRINTABLE: OUR “WHEN... THEN...” CHART

Put it on the fridge. Point to it instead of repeating yourself.

When I’m dressed, **then** I can play until we leave.

When my toys are away, **then** we get out something new.

When my teeth are brushed, **then** we read a story.

When my pajamas are on, **then** I pick the book.

When _____, **then** _____.

When _____, **then** _____.

Tip: the “then” should be something that was going to happen anyway. You’re showing the order of the day, not offering a new prize.

CHAPTER 7

Table Talk: Mealtimes Without the Battle

Arlo is three. Dinner is on the table, and Arlo is under it. When his dad gets him into his booster seat, he slides out again. When he finally stays, he looks at his plate and announces, “Yuck. I’m not eating that.”

Mealtimes pack a lot of asks into a short time: come to the table, sit down, stay sitting, eat, don’t throw, say please. No wonder they turn into battles.

This chapter is about **behavior at the table**, not nutrition. For what and how much children should eat, your pediatrician is the right person to ask. But one idea from feeding experts makes every moment in this chapter easier, so let’s start there.

Your job and their job

Dietitian and family therapist Ellyn Satter describes a **division of responsibility** in feeding. For toddlers and older children, the parent decides *what* food is served, *when* and *where*. The child decides *how much* to eat, and *whether* to eat at all.²⁷

This takes a huge weight off mealtimes. It means you don’t have to win the “three more bites” battle. Your job is to put the food on the table, at the table, at mealtime, and to keep the table pleasant. Your child’s job is to decide how much of it goes in. That’s a division you can hold calmly, and it leaves very little to fight about.

27. Ellyn Satter Institute, “Ellyn Satter’s Division of Responsibility in Feeding.”

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Moment 18: Won't come to the table

"Dinner's ready!" and nobody comes

What's going on: Dinner means stopping play, and young children don't feel hungry on a schedule. "Dinner's ready!" from the kitchen is easy to ignore.

Say this:

[Five minutes before:] **"Five minutes until dinner. Finish your puzzle piece."**

[At dinner time, walk over:] **"Dinner's on the table. Come sit with us, please."**

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* **"Dinner time. Do you want to carry the napkins or the spoons?"**
- *Rung 2:* **"Let's walk together."** *[Take their hand.]*
- *Rung 3:* **"We're starting. Your plate is ready when you are."** Start eating without chasing them. Dinner is at dinner time. There's no separate meal later, and the next food comes at the next planned snack or meal.²⁸

Instead of: "Get here NOW or there's no dinner!"

Try: **"Dinner's on the table. We'd love you to join us."** *[And start eating.]*

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Carry them to the table with a song. Toddlers often come happily once they're there.
- **4-5:** Give them a job that starts at the table: pouring water, handing out napkins.
- **6-7:** Let them help make one part of the meal, so dinner is partly theirs.

28. Ellyn Satter Institute, "Ellyn Satter's Division of Responsibility in Feeding."

Next time: Give the five-minute warning every night, and keep dinner around the same time. A predictable dinner is easier to come to.

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Moment 19: Won't stay in the seat

Up, down, under the table, back again

What's going on: Young children can only sit still for a short time, and a long family dinner is often longer than they can manage. Getting up is often their body saying "I'm done."

Say this:

"Bottom on the chair, please."

If they still don't:

- **Rung 1:** "Bottom on the chair. Are you still eating, or are you done?"
- **Rung 2:** "Leaving the table means you're done eating." If they leave, calmly clear their plate. Remember, how much to eat is their decision.²⁹
- **Rung 4:** No lecture. "Okay. You can play quietly while we finish."

Instead of: "Sit DOWN! How many times do I have to tell you?"

Try: "Are you done, or still eating?" Let the answer decide.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Expect a short meal. A booster or high chair helps, and it's okay if they're done before you are.
- **4–5:** Teach a polite way to leave: "May I be excused?"
- **6–7:** Ask them to stay at the table a little after eating, for a bit of family talk. Keep it short and pleasant.

29. Ellyn Satter Institute, "Ellyn Satter's Division of Responsibility in Feeding."

Next time: Serve their plate when they sit down, not five minutes before. Less waiting means less wandering.

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Moment 20: “Yuck! I’m not eating that!”

New or disliked food

What’s going on: Many young children are cautious about new foods. “Yuck” is often just “I don’t know this one.” The more pressure they feel to eat it, the more it becomes a battle.

Say this:

“You don’t have to eat it. You can leave it on the side of your plate.”

[And for the word “yuck”:] **“In our family we say ‘No, thank you.’”**

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* **“Try again with ‘No, thank you.’”**
- *Rung 2:* If they keep saying “yuck” to get a reaction, don’t give one. Turn the talk to something else. Minor behaviors like this often fade when they stop getting attention.³⁰

Instead of: “Just three more bites, and then you can get down.”

Try: “You don’t have to eat it. Is your tummy still hungry, or all full?”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Put a tiny amount of the new food next to something they usually eat. No comments, no pressure.
- **4–5:** Let them describe it instead of eating it: **“Is it crunchy or soft?”**
- **6–7:** Invite them to help choose or cook one new food each week.

30. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Redirecting Attention.”

Next time: Serve at least one food your child usually eats at every meal, alongside whatever else is on the table. They'll always have something to eat, and you won't need to make a separate meal.

If you're worried about your child's growth, weight, or a very short list of foods they'll eat, talk to your pediatrician.

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Moment 21: Playing with or dropping food

Food art, food throwing, food on the floor

What's going on: Sometimes it's experimenting: what happens if I squish this? Often, especially with toddlers, it's a sign they're full.

Say this:

"Food stays on the plate. Are you done, or still eating?"

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1: "Spoon to your mouth, please. Or are you all done?"*
- *Rung 3: "Dropping food tells me you're done." [Calmly take the plate away.]*
- *Rung 4: "Okay, all done. Let's wipe your hands." No scolding.*

Instead of: "Stop playing with your food!"

Try: "Food is for eating. Show me how you eat it."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Some mess is normal. Give them finger foods and a way to say "all done," like a hand sign.
- **4-5:** Say the rule once, then follow through by ending the meal.
- **6-7:** If they drop food on purpose, they help clean it up: **"Let's wipe it together."**

Next time: Smaller portions. A child can always ask for more. A big plate is an invitation to play.

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Moment 22: Forgetting please and thank you

“Give me the milk!”

What’s going on: Manners are habits, and habits take a long time to build. Young children forget, especially when they’re hungry or excited. It’s rarely rudeness.

Say this:

[Quietly, without a lecture:] **“Try that again with ‘please.’”**

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* **“I’ll pass the milk when I hear ‘please.’”** *[Then wait, calmly.]*
- *Rung 4:* As soon as they say it, pass it with a smile. **“Thank you for asking nicely.”**

Instead of: “What do you SAY?” (Especially in front of other people.)

Try: Model it, every time. **“Please pass the potatoes.” “Thank you!”** Children pick up a lot from what they hear you say every day.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Say it for them and let them copy: **“Milk, please.”** Then pass it.
- **4–5:** A quiet reminder: **“Magic words?”** is fine, as long as it’s warm.
- **6–7:** Notice it out loud when they remember on their own: **“You said thank you to Grandma all by yourself.”**

Next time: Make manners part of the routine, not a test. Say please and thank you to your child, too. They’ll hear it many times a day.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Plan one family meal with a two-rule table plan. Choose two simple rules, like “bottoms on chairs” and “food stays on the plate,” and tell everyone before the meal starts. Follow through on both, calmly, and notice out loud when your child keeps them.

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CHAPTER 8

Whining, Interrupting and Rude Words

Iris is six. Her mom is on the phone with the doctor's office, trying to book an appointment. "Mom. Mom. Mom. MOM. Moooooom." Iris tugs her sleeve. Then she whines, "You're not *listening* to me!"

Her mom covers the phone. "Not now!" Two seconds later: "Mom. Mom. Mom."

The moments in this chapter are less about doing a task and more about *how* your child talks to you. Whining, interrupting, silly-rude words and back-talk are all ways of getting your attention. The trick is to teach your child a better way to get it, and then make sure the better way works.

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Moment 23: The whiny voice

"But I waaaaant it!"

What's going on: Whining is hard to ignore, which is exactly why it works. If the whine gets a faster answer than the regular voice, your child will keep using it.

Say this:

"I want to help. I can't understand the whiny voice. Can you ask me in your regular voice?"

[When they do, answer quickly, even if the answer is no.]

If they still don't:

- **Rung 1:** “Try again in your regular voice. Like this:” *[Show them, in a calm voice.]*
- **Rung 2:** Turn your attention to something else until the regular voice comes back. The CDC suggests this for minor behaviors like whining, and warns that it may get worse when you first start.³¹
- **Rung 4:** The moment the regular voice comes back, turn to them warmly. “Thanks for asking like that. What did you need?”

Instead of: Giving in after the tenth whine.

Try: Answer the regular voice, every time. Ignore the whine, every time.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Give them the words to copy: “Say, ‘Milk, please.’”
- **4–5:** Practice “whiny voice” and “regular voice” as a game when everyone’s calm. It’s often funny, and it makes the difference clear.
- **6–7:** A quiet signal works: touch your ear to mean “I’ll listen to your regular voice.”

Next time: Whining can show up when kids are hungry, tired or haven’t had much of you that day. A snack and a few minutes of real attention can prevent a lot of it.

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31. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Redirecting Attention.”

Moment 24: Interrupting

When you're on the phone or talking to someone

What's going on: Young children find waiting very hard, and they don't yet know how to get your attention politely. To them, everything feels urgent right now.

Say this:

[Teach this when calm:] “When I’m talking and you need me, put your hand on my arm. I’ll put my hand on yours, so you know I know you’re waiting. Then I’ll turn to you as soon as I can.”

[In the moment:] “I’m talking to Grandma. Hand on my arm, please.”

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* “Hand on my arm. I’ll be with you in a minute.” *[Then turn back to your call.]*
- *Rung 2:* If the interrupting keeps going, gently turn your attention back to your call and keep it there. The CDC lists interrupting as one of the minor behaviors where redirecting your attention works best.³²
- *Rung 4:* Turn to them as soon as you can, and thank them: “You waited with your hand on my arm. Thank you. What did you want to tell me?”

Always say this too: “If someone is hurt or something’s dangerous, interrupt me right away.”

Instead of: “Not now! Not now! I said NOT NOW!”

Try: “Hand on my arm.” Then keep your promise to turn to them soon.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** They can only wait a few seconds. Keep calls short, or keep a “phone basket” of special toys for call time.

32. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Redirecting Attention.”

- **4–5:** Keep the wait short at first, then slowly make it longer as they get better at it.
- **6–7:** Teach them to say **“Excuse me”** and wait for you to look at them.

Next time: Before a call, give your child a few minutes of attention and set them up with something to do. **“I’m going to make a phone call. Here’s your drawing pad. Hand on my arm if you need me.”**

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Moment 25: Potty words and silly-rude talk

“Poopy-head!” (followed by giggles)

What’s going on: Many preschoolers discover that certain words get big reactions: laughter from siblings, shock from adults. Big reactions make the words more fun.

Say this:

[Calm, almost bored:] **“Potty words are for the bathroom.”**

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* **“If you want to say potty words, you can go to the bathroom and say them there.”**
- *Rung 2:* Don’t react. Turn the conversation to something else. Without an audience, the words lose their magic.
- *Rung 3 (if it’s aimed at someone):* **“That word hurt your sister’s feelings. Let’s take a break from playing together for a few minutes.”**

Instead of: Gasping, laughing, or a long talk about bad words.

Try: The same calm line, every time: **“Potty words are for the bathroom.”**

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** They often don’t know what the words mean. A calm **“We don’t say that”** and a change of subject is enough.

- 4–5: The bathroom rule works well at this age. It’s funny, and it’s fair.
- 6–7: Talk, when calm, about words that hurt versus words that are just silly.

Next time: Give silly a time and place. A few minutes of “silly word time” at bath time can take the fun out of saying them at the dinner table.

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Moment 26: “You’re stupid!” “Go away!”

Rude words when they’re not really upset

What’s going on: Your child is trying out strong words to see what they do. If they’re upset and overwhelmed, that’s a different moment: see *The Meltdown Playbook*, Moment 30. This moment is the calm, testing version.

Say this:

“That’s a hurtful word. You can say, ‘I don’t like that.’”

Or: “Try that again in a kind way.”

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* “I’ll listen when you can say it kindly. Try again.”
- *Rung 2:* Step away briefly and calmly. “I’m going to finish the dishes. I’ll come back when you’re ready to talk kindly.”
- *Rung 4:* When they try again, respond warmly. “Thanks. Now I understand. You don’t want to stop playing.”

Instead of: “Don’t you dare talk to me like that!”

Try: “Try that again in a kind way.” Calm, short, and gives them a way back.

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Give them the words: “Say, ‘Stop, please.’”

- **4–5:** Teach the difference between feeling words and hurting words: **“You can say ‘I’m mad.’ You can’t call names.”**
- **6–7:** When calm, ask what they were trying to say. Often it’s “I’m angry and I don’t know how to say it.”

Next time: Practice the words for strong feelings (“I’m mad,” “That’s not fair,” “I need a break”) when everyone is calm, so they’re ready when your child needs them.

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Moment 27: Eye-rolls and back-talk

Ages 5 to 7: “Ugh. Fine. Whatever.”

What’s going on: Older preschoolers and early school-age kids are practicing independence, and they sometimes copy tones they hear from older kids or on screens. An eye-roll is usually a feeling, not a plan.

Say this:

[Let the eye-roll go. Respond to the task, not the attitude.]

“Backpack on the hook, please.”

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* If the words are rude: **“I’ll listen when you say it in a respectful voice. Try again.”**
- *Rung 2:* Follow through on the original ask as usual. **“When your backpack is on the hook, then you can go play.”**
- *Rung 3:* Save consequences for what they *do* (not hanging the backpack), not for an eye-roll.

Instead of: “Don’t you roll your eyes at me!”

Try: Ignore the eye-roll. Follow through on the ask. Talk about tone later, when calm.

Age tweaks:

- **5:** Often copying. Name it lightly: **“Whoa, that was a big sigh. Want to try that again?”**
- **6–7:** When calm, talk about it: **“When you said ‘whatever,’ it sounded like you were really frustrated. What was going on?”**

Next time: Back-talk can show up when kids feel bossed around all day. More choices, a few minutes of one-on-one time, and fewer instructions can take a lot of the heat out of it.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Teach the “hand on my arm” signal today. Practice it twice when nothing is at stake: pretend to be on the phone, let your child put their hand on your arm, cover it with yours, and then turn to them with a smile. The first real phone call will go better for the practice.

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CHAPTER 9

Trickier Moments

Oscar is five. At the grocery store, he has squeezed every avocado in the bin, opened a box of crackers “just to look,” and is now standing on the bottom shelf of the cereal aisle. His mom can feel other shoppers watching.

The three moments in this chapter happen away from home, or around a harder topic. Other people may be watching, the rules may be different, and you may feel the pressure to fix it *fast*. The same tools still work. They just work best when you plan ahead.

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Moment 28: Not listening at someone else's house

Playdates and visits

What's going on: New places are exciting, the rules are different, and your child may be testing whether your rules still count when you're a guest. You may also feel judged, which makes it harder to stay calm.

Say this:

[Before you go in:] “At Nia's house, we follow Nia's mom's rules. Toys stay in the playroom. When I say ‘two more minutes,’ it's almost time to go.”

[In the moment, crouched down, quietly:] “At Nia's house, toys stay in the playroom, please.”

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* “Toys in the playroom. Do you want to carry it back, or should I?”
- *Rung 2:* Walk them back to the playroom yourself.
- *Rung 3:* “It’s hard to follow the rules today, so we’re going home a little early. We’ll try again next time.” Say goodbye politely and leave, without a scene or a lecture.

Instead of: Scolding in front of the other family.

Try: Crouch down and speak quietly, just to your child. Your ask is between the two of you.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Stay close. Toddlers need you nearby in new places to follow any rule at all.
- **4–5:** Practice the rules in the car: “What’s the toy rule at Nia’s house?”
- **6–7:** Let them help plan: “What will help you remember the rules there?”

Next time: Plan your exit line before you arrive, and tell your child what it is. “When I say ‘two more minutes,’ we’re leaving soon.” Then use that exact line when it’s time, and leave when the two minutes are up.

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Moment 29: Touching everything in a store

Grabbing, squeezing, climbing the shelves

What’s going on: A store is full of bright, touchable things, and small hands want to explore. Your child isn’t being naughty. Their hands just don’t have a job.

Say this:

“You can look with your eyes. Hands on the cart, please.”

Or give them a job: “Can you be the finder? Find me the bananas.”

If they still don’t:

- *Rung 1:* “Hands on the cart. Do you want to push with me or hold the list?”
- *Rung 2:* “I’ll help your hands.” [*Take their hand, or lift them into the cart seat.*]
- *Rung 3:* “We’re leaving this aisle.” [*Move on to the next aisle, calmly.*]

Instead of: “Don’t touch anything!”

Try: Give hands something to do: “Hold the list,” “Push the cart,” “Put the apples in the bag.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Use the cart seat. Give them one safe item to hold, like a box of pasta.
- 4–5: “Eyes only” game: they spot things and tell you, but hands stay on the cart.
- 6–7: Give them a short list of their own and a job: “Find these three things.”

Next time: Before you go in, tell them their job. “Today you’re the finder. Your job is the bananas and the yogurt.” A child with a job is less likely to make up their own.

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Moment 30: “I didn’t do it!”

Lying

What’s going on: You know there’s crayon on the wall. Your child is holding the crayon. And they’re telling you they didn’t do it.

Here’s something that may help: lying is a normal step in development. Research led by psychologist Kang Lee found that about 30% of verbal 2-year-olds try to fool their parents at some point,

about half of 3-year-olds do it regularly, and by ages 5 to 7 it's seen in nearly all healthy children.³³ Lying takes thinking skills, like understanding that you don't know what they know.

That doesn't make lying okay. But it does mean your child isn't on the way to becoming a bad person. They're learning, and you can help them learn honesty.

Say this:

[Don't ask a question you already know the answer to. Say what you see.]

"I see crayon on the wall. Let's clean it together."

[If they tell you the truth:] **"Thank you for telling me the truth. That was brave. Now let's fix it."**

If they still don't:

- *Rung 1:* If they insist they didn't do it, don't argue. **"The wall needs cleaning. Here's your cloth."**
- *Rung 3:* The consequence is about the *action*, not the lie: **"Crayons are put away for the afternoon."**
- *Rung 4:* Move on. No lecture about lying.

Instead of: "Did you draw on the wall?" (They know you know, and now they have to decide whether to lie.) Or: "Don't you dare lie to me!"

Try: "I see _____. What can we do to fix it?"

Harsh punishment tends to backfire here. In one study, 3- and 4-year-olds from a school with harsh punishments lied more often about breaking a rule than children from a school without them.³⁴ Children who expect a big punishment have more reason to hide the truth. Children who know they'll be helped to fix things have more reason to tell it.

33. Association for Psychological Science, "Children's Lies Are a Sign of Cognitive Progress," reporting research led by Kang Lee, University of Toronto.

34. Talwar, V., & Lee, K., "A Punitive Environment Fosters Children's Dishonesty: A Natural Experiment," *Child Development* 82(6), 1751–1758 (2011).

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Often it's wishful thinking, not a plan to trick you. Just say what happened and help fix it.
- **4–5:** Praise honesty every time you see it: **"You told me the truth even though it was hard."**
- **6–7:** Talk, when calm, about trust: **"When you tell me the truth, I know I can believe you."**

Next time: Make telling the truth the easier choice. When your child admits something, your first words should be thanks, then the fix. Over time, that's what they'll remember.

. . .

Your 5-Minute Action

Plan your exit line for the next visit. Think of the next playdate, family visit or store trip. Decide now on the one sentence that will mean "we're leaving soon," tell your child before you go, and use it exactly when it's time.

. . .

CHAPTER 10

When They Still Won't Listen

Ezra is four. For a week, his mom has used the One Clear Ask every morning. She walks over, gets his eyes, says “Shoes on, please,” and waits. Some mornings it works on the first try. But this morning, Ezra looked right at her, said “No,” and lay down on the floor.

It's not working, she thinks. Maybe this method is fine for other kids. Not mine.

If you're feeling that way, this chapter is for you. Before you decide something isn't working, let's check how you're measuring it, what might be getting in the way, and when it's time to ask for more help.

Measure progress the right way

No method gets a child to listen every time. If that's the test, everything fails. Here's what progress really looks like:

- **Fewer repeats.** You used to ask five times. Now it's usually once or twice.
- **Faster starts.** Your child begins moving sooner after you ask.
- **Less climbing.** You get to Rung 3 of the ladder less often than you did.
- **A calmer you.** You yell less, even on hard days.

Get out the tally you started in Chapter 2. Do one more hour of counting now, and compare. Progress often shows up in the numbers before it shows up in your feelings.

Expect it to get worse before it gets better

When you change how you respond, many children push harder at first to see whether the change is real. The CDC warns parents about this when they start ignoring whining: the behavior may get worse at first.³⁵ The same can happen with a new follow-through.

This is a good sign, not a bad one. It means your child noticed the change. Keep going, with the same words, for at least a week before you judge.

Check your asks

Sometimes the method slips without us noticing. Run through these five questions:

1. **Am I still asking from far away?** Walking over is the step most of us drop first.
2. **Am I asking questions?** “Can you...?” and “...okay?” creep back in.
3. **Am I giving too many instructions?** If your tally showed a lot of marks, try cutting the number of asks in half. Let the small stuff go.
4. **Am I waiting?** Or am I repeating after two seconds?
5. **Am I following through every time?** If the follow-through happens only some of the time, the first ask will only work some of the time.

Pick the one that sounds most like you this week, and fix just that one.

35. CDC, *Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers*, “Redirecting Attention.”

Are the grown-ups saying the same thing?

Child psychiatrists call consistency and predictability the cornerstones of discipline.³⁶ That's hard when two or three adults are asking in different ways.

You don't need to agree on everything. Start small:

- **Three shared phrases.** For example: "Shoes on, please." "Rule check." "When... then..."
- **One shared consequence** for the moment that's hardest in your house.
- **Back each other up.** If one adult asks, the other doesn't take over or undo it. They can say, "**Mom asked. I'll wait with you.**"

For grandparents and sitters, give them the pocket cards from Chapters 1 and 3. A one-page card is easier to share than a whole philosophy.

Check underneath

If your child is suddenly much harder to reach, look at what's going on underneath. If you've read *The Meltdown Playbook*, you'll remember **HALT**: is your child Hungry, Angry, Lonely or Tired? Is there a big change going on, like a new baby, a move or a new school? Children who are running on empty have less to give to listening. Sometimes the fix is a snack, an earlier bedtime or ten minutes of your full attention, not a better script.

When "won't" turns into "can't"

Sometimes refusing turns into falling apart: screaming, crying, kicking. At that point your child can't listen, however clear your ask is. Switch to feelings first, help them calm down, and come back to the task afterward. That's what *The Meltdown Playbook* is for.

36. American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry, *Facts for Families* No. 43, "Discipline."

When to talk to your pediatrician

Many listening struggles are a normal part of growing up. But sometimes they're a sign that something else needs attention. Please talk to your child's doctor if:

- **Your child often doesn't follow directions, even simple ones, even when you're close and they're looking at you.** The CDC notes that this can be mistaken for not paying attention or ignoring, when it may actually be a hearing problem. If you think your child might have hearing loss, ask their doctor for a hearing check as soon as possible.³⁷
- **Listening is hard for your child everywhere,** at home, at daycare and at school, and teachers or caregivers have raised concerns too.
- **Your child has lost skills they used to have,** like words, or following simple routines they used to follow.³⁸
- **Anyone is getting hurt,** or the behavior feels unsafe.
- **You're worried.** You know your child best. You never need a reason beyond that to ask.

Bring your tally and a few examples. Concrete notes make the conversation with your doctor much more useful.

This book can't diagnose anything, and nothing here replaces a conversation with someone who knows your child.

Your 5-Minute Action

Notice which rung made the biggest difference. Think back over the past week. Was it getting close? The reminder with a choice? Helping hands? "When... then..."? Write it down. That's your strongest tool, and it's the one to reach for first on a hard day.

. . .

37. CDC, "Signs and Symptoms of Hearing Loss in Children."

38. CDC, "Learn the Signs. Act Early."

PART 3

A Home That Listens

The best ask is the one you don't need to make.

CHAPTER 11

Fewer Reminders: Let the Routine Do the Talking

It's 7:30 on a school morning. Ada is six and her brother Sol is three. In the last half hour, their dad has said: "Get up." "Get dressed." "Not that shirt." "Eat your toast." "Sit down." "Stop kicking your brother." "Teeth." "Shoes." "Where's your backpack?" "Coat." "Hurry up." "COAT."

By the time they reach the car, he's given more instructions than he can count, and everyone is cross.

Parts 1 and 2 of this book help you make each ask count. This last part is about needing fewer of them. When the day has a shape that everyone knows, the routine does a lot of the talking for you, and your words matter more because there are fewer of them.

Sort your asks into three piles

Look back at the tally you kept in Chapter 2. Then sort your everyday asks into three piles:

Must. Safety, health and getting out the door. Car seats, hand-holding near roads, teeth, coats in the cold. These you follow through on every time.

Matters. A few things you care about for your family: kind words, toys away before dinner, sitting for meals. Pick no more than three or four.

Let go. Everything else. The mismatched socks, the shirt you wouldn't have picked, the way they eat their toast. Let these go, at least for now.

Every ask you drop from the third pile makes the first two piles easier to follow through on. It's much easier to mean every ask when there are fewer of them.

Write your family rules

A few clear family rules can replace dozens of separate instructions. Child psychiatrists recommend setting clear rules and explaining why they matter.³⁹ Here's how to make them work for young children.

Keep them few. Three to five rules. More than that, and nobody remembers them.

Say what to do. "We use gentle hands" works better than "No hitting." Just like the One Clear Ask, a rule should tell your child what *to do*.

Keep them short. Each rule should fit on one line and be easy to say out loud.

Make them together. Ask your child: "What rules would help our family get along?"

Rules your child helped write feel like theirs, not just yours, and even a three-year-old can choose the picture that goes next to a rule.

Explain the why, once. "We walk inside, so nobody gets hurt." Then post the rules where everyone can see them.

Some examples to get you started:

- We use gentle hands.
- We use kind words.

39. American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry, *Facts for Families* No. 43, "Discipline."

- **We walk inside.**
- **We put toys away before new ones come out.**
- **When a grown-up asks, we answer.**

Once your rules are up, you can use the short reminder from Moment 12: **“Rule check.”** Point to the poster. Let the rule do the work, instead of starting a new speech.

Let the chart be the boss

For the parts of the day that happen the same way every time (mornings, bedtime, getting out the door), a **picture routine chart** can save you dozens of instructions.

Draw or print a simple picture for each step, in order: toilet, clothes, breakfast, teeth, shoes, coat. Put it where it’s needed, at your child’s eye level.

Then, instead of giving the instruction, ask about the chart:

“What’s next on the chart?”

This small change does a lot. Your child finds the answer themselves, so it doesn’t feel like being bossed. You don’t have to repeat yourself, because the chart says it for you. And when they’re stuck, the chart is the one asking, not you.

If you have *The Meltdown Playbook*, its routine chart in Chapter 7 works well here.

Give warnings that work

Many listening battles start with a surprise. One minute your child is playing; the next, you need them in the car. A warning before the switch makes the ask easier to follow.

Make the warning **concrete**. “Five more minutes” means little to a young child. **“Two more pages, then bath”** or **“One more turn on the slide, then shoes”** is something they can count.

Then, when the warning runs out, use the One Clear Ask, and follow through.

Turn chores into jobs

A child with a job doesn't need as many instructions. Moment 17 showed you how to give your child a named job, like "table captain" or "sock matcher." Once a job is part of the routine, it stops being an ask at all. It's just what happens.

Fill their cup before you ask

Some asks go badly simply because your child hasn't had much of your attention that day. A few minutes of one-on-one time, where your child leads the play and you just join in, can make the rest of the day go more smoothly. In *The Meltdown Playbook*, this is called "special time." Even five minutes a day helps.

It sounds like the opposite of discipline. But a child who feels connected to you has more reason to cooperate when you ask.

Your 5-Minute Action

Write your family rules together and post them. Sit down with your child this week. Choose three to five rules, word them as what to *do*, and add a drawing or picture for each one. Put the poster where everyone will see it, and start using "Rule check."

PRINTABLE: OUR FAMILY RULES

Three to five rules. Say what to do. Draw a picture for each one.

In our family:

1. We _____
2. We _____
3. We _____
4. We _____
5. We _____

When someone forgets, we say: "Rule check."

Signed by everyone: _____

CHAPTER 12

Your 14-Day Listening Challenge

You now have everything in this book: the One Clear Ask, the Follow-Through Ladder, 30 scripts for everyday moments, and the routines that cut down how often you need to ask at all.

That's a lot to take in. The easiest way to lose it is to try everything at once for two days and then slide back into the old loop. So this chapter turns the book into a simple two-week challenge: **one small step a day, building to the full method.**

How the challenge works

- **Each day has one small action**, usually five minutes or less.
- **Missed a day? Just carry on.** Don't restart. The challenge works even when you do it imperfectly.
- **Count on Day 1 and Day 14.** One hour of tallying at the start and the end, so you can see what changed.
- **Check in every few days.** A couple of quick questions help you notice progress, even when it's slow.

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Days 1 to 3: Make the first ask count

Focus: the One Clear Ask (Chapter 1)

- **Day 1:** Count for one busy hour. A mark for every ask, a circle for every repeat. Write the totals in the tracker below. No changes yet. Just count.

- **Day 2:** Pick one request you make every day. Use all five steps for it, every time: get close, get their eyes, say it short, wait, follow through.
- **Day 3:** Listen for questions and “okay?” in your asks. Swap each one for a short, kind statement: **“Shoes on, please.”**

Check-in: Which of the five steps is hardest for me? (Often it’s walking over, or waiting.)

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Days 4 to 7: Never stuck after “no”

Focus: the Follow-Through Ladder (Chapter 3)

- **Day 4:** Fill in your Consequence Picker for your three hardest moments.
- **Day 5:** Practice Rung 1 every time it’s needed: one reminder, with a choice.
- **Day 6:** Use helping hands or “When... then...” instead of a third ask.
- **Day 7:** Catch your child listening five times today, and say exactly what they did. **“You came the first time I called. Thank you.”**

Check-in: Did I reach for a threat or a yell less often this week? Which rung do I use most?

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Days 8 to 11: Your moments

Focus: the script cards (Chapters 4 to 9)

- **Day 8:** Look at your Day 1 tally. Pick the three moments that cost you the most repeats, and find them in the Find Your Moment list.
- **Day 9:** Read the **Say this** lines for all three out loud, twice. Then use one.

- **Day 10:** Use the other two.
- **Day 11:** For a moment that isn't in the book, build your own: One Clear Ask, then the ladder.

Check-in: Is one of my three moments easier than it was a week ago?

. . .

Days 12 to 14: Fewer asks

Focus: rules and routines (Chapter 11)

- **Day 12:** Write your family rules together and put the poster up.
- **Day 13:** Make a picture routine chart or a “When... then...” chart for your hardest time of day. Use “**What’s next on the chart?**” instead of an instruction.
- **Day 14:** Count again, for the same busy hour as Day 1. Write the totals in the tracker.

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Your Day 14 check-in

Compare your Day 1 and Day 14 numbers, then answer honestly. There are no wrong answers.

1. Am I giving **fewer instructions** than two weeks ago?
2. Am I **repeating myself less**? (Look at the circles.)
3. Is my child **starting sooner** after I ask, at least some of the time?
4. Do I yell less, even on hard days?
5. Which **step or rung** made the biggest difference?
6. Which moment is **still hard**? (Go back to its card, or check Chapter 10.)

If you see even a small change, that’s real progress. A child who used to need five asks and now needs two has learned something

important: *when this grown-up asks, it happens*. That's the whole goal. Keep the tools that work, drop the ones that don't, and come back to this book whenever a new stage brings new battles.

And if, after two weeks of steady effort, listening is getting harder instead of easier, or something worries you, look at the signs in Chapter 10 and talk to your pediatrician. Asking for help is part of the plan, not a failure of it.

PRINTABLE: 14-DAY LISTENING CHALLENGE TRACKER

*Day 1 and Day 14: count for the same busy hour. Asks = marks.
Repeats = circles.*

Day 1: Asks _____ Repeats _____

Day 14: Asks _____ Repeats _____

Day 2: One Clear Ask, one request: _____

Day 3: Questions swapped for statements: _____

Day 4: Consequence Picker filled in. Yes / Not yet

Day 5: Rung 1 (reminder with a choice): _____

Day 6: Helping hands / "When... then...": _____

Day 7: Caught them listening ____ times.

Day 8: My three moments: _____

Day 9: Used the card for: _____

Day 10: Used the cards for: _____

Day 11: My own script for: _____

Day 12: Family rules poster up. Yes / Not yet

Day 13: Chart made for: _____

The tool that helped most: _____

Thank You for Reading

You made it to the end, and that says a lot about how much you care. Now go do Day 1.

If this book helped you, would you take a moment to leave an honest review? Reviews help other parents decide whether this book is right for them, and every one gets read.

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The 30 Scripts Cheat Sheet

Short versions of every script in Part 2. Photocopy these pages or take a photo for your phone. Always start with the One Clear Ask: get close, get their eyes, say it short, wait, follow through.

When they tune you out (Chapter 4) *Walk over first.*

1. **Mid-play:** “That’s a big sticker picture. Coat on, please.”
2. **Come here:** “Time to come inside, please. Snack is ready.”
3. **“In a minute!”:** “One more page, then teeth.” Then: “Teeth now, please.”
4. **Stop that:** “Feet on the floor, please. Jumping is for outside.”
5. **One parent, not the other:** “I asked you. I’ll help you do it.”
6. **“Can I? Can I?”:** “The answer is no for today. Asked and answered.”

No, defiance and power struggles (Chapter 5) *Don’t pick up the rope.*

7. **“No!”:** “Coat on. Do you want to zip it yourself, or should I?”
8. **“You can’t make me!”:** “You’re right. I can’t make you want to. Teeth now, then we’ll read.”
9. **Running off:** Near roads, hold hands first. In safe places: “Freeze! Come back to me, please.”
10. **Doing it while watching you:** “Cup stays on the table. If it drops again, the cup goes away.”
11. **“But why?”:** One short reason, once. “I told you why. Teeth now, please.”

12. **Breaking a rule:** “Rule check: balls are for outside. Outside or in the basket?”

Cleanup and chores (Chapter 6) *One step at a time.*

13. **Toy cleanup:** “Cars in the red bin, please.” Then: “Now books on the shelf.”
14. **“I can’t do it!”:** “You do the first part, and I’ll help with the rest.”
15. **Dawdling:** “Socks.” Wait. “Now shirt.” Wait. “Now pants.”
16. **Bath time:** “Ducks or the boat?” Getting out: “Two more splashes, then the plug comes out.”
17. **Helping out:** “Table captain! A spoon by every plate, please.”

Mealtimes (Chapter 7) *You decide what, when and where. They decide how much.*

18. **Coming to the table:** “Dinner’s on the table. Come sit with us, please.”
19. **Staying seated:** “Bottom on the chair. Are you still eating, or are you done?”
20. **“Yuck!”:** “You don’t have to eat it. In our family we say ‘No, thank you.’”
21. **Dropping food:** “Food stays on the plate. Are you done, or still eating?”
22. **Please and thank you:** “Try that again with ‘please.’”

Whining, interrupting and rude words (Chapter 8) *Answer the better way, every time.*

23. **Whining:** “I can’t understand the whiny voice. Can you ask in your regular voice?”
24. **Interrupting:** “I’m talking to Grandma. Hand on my arm, please.”
25. **Potty words:** “Potty words are for the bathroom.”

26. **“You’re stupid!”:** “That’s a hurtful word. Try that again in a kind way.”

27. **Eye-rolls:** Let it go. “Backpack on the hook, please.”

Trickier moments (Chapter 9) *Plan ahead.*

28. **Someone else’s house:** “At Nia’s house, toys stay in the playroom, please.”

29. **The store:** “You can look with your eyes. Hands on the cart, please.”

30. **“I didn’t do it!”:** “I see crayon on the wall. Let’s clean it together.”

When they still don’t: One reminder, with a choice. Helping hands, or “When... then...” A calm consequence: related, small, soon. Then move on.

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Hannah Rowe writes short, practical guides that give parents the exact words to use when things get hard. Her Calm Words Parenting series turns child-development research into scripts you can use in the moment, from the middle of a meltdown to the fifth “shoes on,” no parenting degree required.